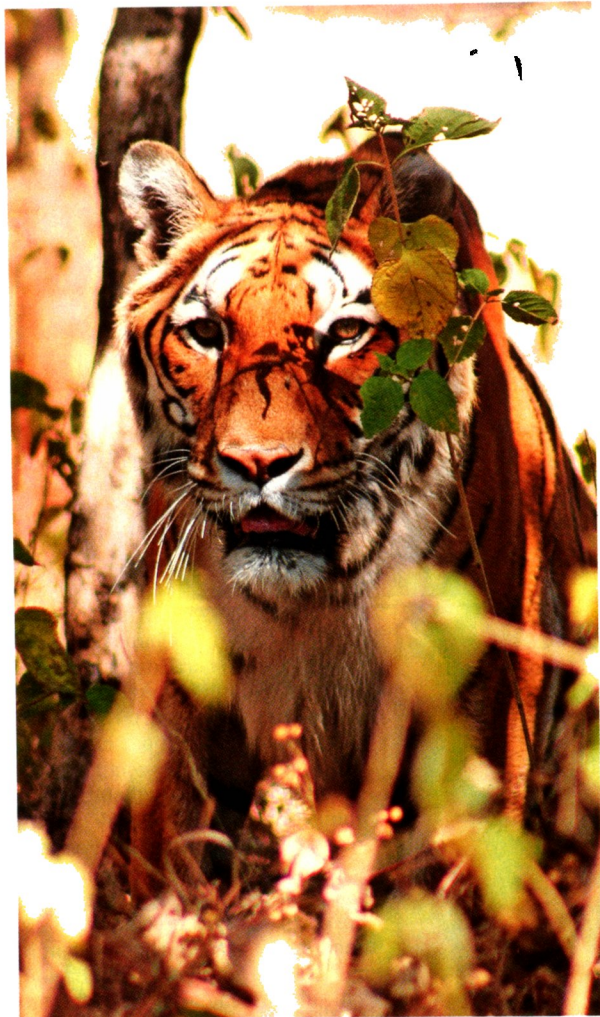


PANKAJ TIWARI



By Ambreesh Mishra
with Mihir Srivastava

The Purge of **PANNA**

India's tiger state, Madhya Pradesh, has become the new disaster zone for the fast disappearing big cat. Forest officials, though, continue to remain in denial.

The elegantly-worded and detailed website of the Madhya Pradesh Government's Forest Department has but one missing element—the number of tigers to be found in its numerous national parks, sanctuaries and reserves. Odd, since Madhya Pradesh is considered India's tiger country. Not odd at all though, if you take into account its dismal recent conservation record—and the unfortunate propensity of authorities to seek refuge in consistent, unyielding denial.

The brutal truth, however, goes nowhere, even while the opposite happens to the state's tigers. Four years ago, Sariska National Park in Rajasthan became the metaphor for the decimation of India's national animal. The nightmare has now shifted location to Panna National Park in Madhya Pradesh.